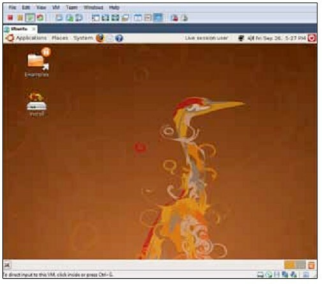

Figure 4: VMware Player runs the guest OS within the Console

Figure 6: VirtualBox running Fedora 13 as the guest OS

following which you can download the software's installer. The installation process is self-explanatory, and yes, there is a EULA that you need to abide by.

Modus operandi

Beginning with Qemu—its interface, though clean, can be confusing for the beginner. If you are a KDE user, you can use qTemu, which serves as a handy emulator. However, if, just like me, you are not a KDE and/or GNOME user, using Qemu's emulator can be quite annoying at times – it simply refuses to blend with your DE. However, once you get accustomed to it, you'll realize that Qemu is one of the best tools for virtualisation. You can enable or disable *Full Acceleration*, decide which processes to log, specify arguments for start-up, and so on. In fact, Qemu offers a much greater level of customisation than most other alternatives.

When it comes to the user interface and mode of operation, VirtualBox emerges as the clear winner. The interface is slick and resembles more of a media player (say, Banshee, for instance). For almost all the operations, there are set-up wizards and the procedures are self-explanatory. The program offers all the abilities that you'd seek in a virtualisation tool, and is well backed by

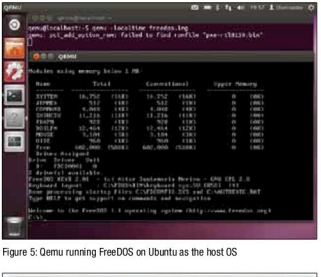

Figure 5: Qemu running FreeDOS on Ubuntu as the host OS

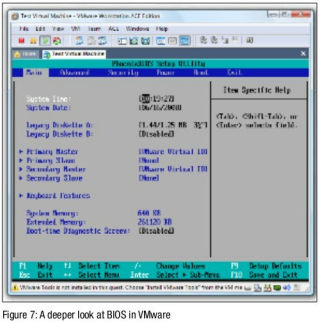

Figure 7: A deeper look at BIOS in VMware

excellent documentation.

Parallels Workstation, on the other hand, is neither as sleek as Qemu nor as polished as VirtualBox. A good portion of it is written in QT, so again, KDE users can feel at home. Speaking of the mode of operation, there is a Virtual Machine Wizard, but since the product itself is more geared towards workstation use rather than home use, the Wizard begins with questions regarding networking, rather than storage. You can set up Ethernet networks, and share host devices from within the wizard. However, such functionality is available in both VirtualBox and Qemu, so it doesn't really make sense why one would opt for a closed source option.

Now, let us take a look at the final option, VMware Player. Unlike its Workstation version, the free Player version does not ask us to connect to a remote or local server upon start-up. Instead, the interface simply offers you a set-up wizard that lets you create virtual machines. VMware Player